won and, vitally, they provided the IDF with time to organize their defenses.

The first major and concerted action by the IDF was Operation Pleshet, an engagement around the city of Isdud against Egyptian forces. For the first time, it included ground attack missions carried out by the IDF using Avia S-199 aircraft provided by Czechoslovakia. Although this wasn't a decisive battle either, it did stop the advance of Egyptian forces, which from this point on were forced to switch to a defensive posture to protect the territory they had already occupied.

The heaviest fighting in the early part of the war involved the 10,000 troops of the Arab Legion from Jordan. These troops were able to seize the fortress of Latrun, which covered the main road between Tel Aviv and Jerusalem. The occupation of this fortress allowed the Arab Legion to cut off supplies to Jewish troops and civilians in Jerusalem, and attempts to retake this strong point became a focus for the IDF. In a series of battles between May 24 and June 18, the IDF suffered almost 600 casualties but was unable to take control of the fortress. Instead, in order to ensure supplies to Jerusalem, IDF engineers and civilian workers constructed a detour that took traffic out of range of the guns in the fortress. This passage, named the Burma Road, was able to bring supplies to Jerusalem even though the fortress at Latrun remained under the control of the Arab Legion.

After taking Latrun, elements of the Arab Legion also mounted an attack on Jerusalem itself from May 19 to 28. This saw Israeli troops and civilians driven out of Arab neighborhoods of the city and from the Old City's Jewish Quarter. During the fighting, the US consul-general in Jerusalem, Thomas C. Wasson, and US Navy Chief Petty Officer Herbert Walker were killed by a sniper. Each side blamed the other for their deaths, and it has never been conclusively proved whether these men were killed by Arab or Israeli forces.